chin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL). Another putative clue could have belonged to Locard's era: a red diary.

The case that has returned to haunt Kerala politics began with an I-T raid in 2019. Searches at the Aluva-based mineral-processing firm CMRL were said to have uncovered a whole mine of scandal—with enough to tar the entire landscape. Records of payments allegedly made to politicians, trade unions, media organisations et al for the company's "smooth functioning".

**Takeaways**

- **SC grants a week's stay on probe against Pinarayi and kin in Exalogic case**
- **Only police, vigilance probe is paused. ED likely to go ahead with its case**
- **Legal battle amidst a flurry of allegations of bribery, hawala transfers**




**BUMPY RIDE** Former CM Vijayan addressing media, Thiruvananthapuram, Jul. 1

The one that invited special scrutiny: a paper trail leading to Veena and her Bengaluru-based firm, Exalogic Solutions. The controversy became public in 2023. A posse of agencies—ED, Serious Fraud Investigation Office, state vigilance—chased the spoor along various lines, alleging payments in the range of Rs 1.72 crore and Rs 3.28 crore.

## NARROWING THE SPOTLIGHT?

Now, the wider allegations have added a new layer of intrigue to the whole affair. A purported CMRL payment list publicised by BJP leader Shone George straddles party lines, naming chief minister V.D. Satheesan and home minister Ramesh Chennithala. Whether these will invite similar investigative energies immediately, or be kept pending ominously, is part of the chatter.

But the spotlight is pinpointedly on Pinarayi and family, with the judiciary not easing the pressure—till the Supreme Court stepped in with a breather on October 21. Its week-long stay on the police and vigilance probe, however, does not automatically protect the 81-year-old ex-CM from the ED; its summons are scheduled for October 23. So, it's more of a temporary moral reprieve, amidst a bad run of events. On October 9, a single-judge bench of the Kerala High Court had ordered the registration of FIRs. On October 12, state vigilance and the Anti-Corruption Bureau filed two cases, covering the corporate side and the alleged hawala angle, respectively. A division bench subsequently refused to interfere with the single judge's order. The apex court has now allowed Pinarayi to approach the division bench for a rethink.

## A DIARY, A WHATSAPP CHAT

At some point, the story will circle back to the red diary, the key link in the evidentiary chain claimed by the ED. It says it recovered the diary, containing handwritten notes on transactions, during its May 27 search at premises connected to Veena. It attributes the entries to her and say they need to be examined alongside bank records, electronic trails et al. Pinarayi rubbishes the ED claim, saying "no such diary ever existed" and that no case is made out for a prosecution.

According to the ED, the CMRL arrangement had two components: Exalogic was engaged at a monthly retainer of Rs 3 lakh, and Veena was separately appointed in her personal capacity as an IT/marketing consultant at Rs 5 lakh a month. An ED report says she got Rs 45 lakh between January and October 2017 before submitting invoices. The agency alleges the arrangements were a cover, and they owed solely to the fact that she was the daughter of the then CM. The ED says CMRL's former MD has acknowledged as much.

The diary also forms part of a separate trail with allegedly unaccounted funds flowing overseas. One entry, the ED alleges, records 3.49 lakh UAE dirhams (about Rs 85 lakh then) as received by a Dubai-based associate, V.P. Faijaz. According to the ED, K. Varish of Kozhikode has admitted to being an intermediary—allegedly receiving cash sent on Riyas's instructions, then routing it to Faijaz via a hawala operator. Investigators say WhatsApp chats from Varish's phone corroborate this. Apparently with contacts saved under names explicitly referring to "hawala", photos of currency notes and dirham conversion tables. Locard would be aghast. ■